Statement of Teaching Philosophy, by Anyun Chatterjee

My approach to teaching has been developed over eight years of teaching courses in communication and public health at three major universities, including gen-eds like Media and Society, first and fourth year writing seminars, and upper division and honors seminars on Misinformation and The Ethics of Persuasion. Additionally, my teaching philosophy is informed by eight years of professional public health and communication experience, from which I frequently draw examples. These examples make lesson materials more concrete and real-world oriented, which helps my students understand how to apply what they learn in the classroom to their career search, and even their personal lives.

I believe students learn best when they are motivated to learn on their own, so I make it a point to learn what each student cares about so that I can connect the course material to their interests. I work to make each student feel seen by tailoring class meetings so that we can discuss topics related to their career or subjects of interest. I also follow up on conversations in class, or on submitted work, with individualized further reading or materials that I'm confident the student will benefit from based on my understanding of their personal goals. As a result, I have had success in motivating even withdrawn or disinterested students to participate in class discussions, which has long term benefits for their education experience and their career after that.

Social and intellectual connection is at the core of my teaching approach, so I take into consideration the goals and idiosyncrasies of individual students. I encourage participation in many ways, including real time in-class survey tools, which allow all students to see each others' authentic responses without worrying about being identified or confronted. This method also allows me to assess students' attitudes and knowledge regarding the course material. I encourage my students to bring their personal and work experiences to class discussions as well, as my subject areas are heavily woven into the fabric of daily life. I also employ teachbacks by having students explain concepts to the class through the lens of their own experiences.

One of my most impactful practices is a midterm survey where I ask students what is working and what is confusing during the class, and I often substantively change the approach for the remainder of the course based on what the students report is making learning the material easier or harder. This practice has been specifically called out in many of my course evals, which reflect appreciation for my responsiveness to student needs while still upholding high standards.

For example, when teaching skill based courses like public speaking or writing, I have found that from term to term different classes prefer different approaches. One of my writing classes reported in the midterm survey that they wanted more opportunities to write in class because they found a lot of value in my brainstorming exercises, while another writing class reported they wanted more 1-1 writing conferences. In both cases I was able to be responsive and slightly change the cadence of each course in order to improve the learning outcomes for the students.

My teaching approach has been especially rewarding in the interdisciplinary honors seminars I have designed for Drexel University's Pennoni Honors College. In my seminar on misinformation, students explored case studies of health misinformation alongside foundational concepts from communication and social psychology like motivated reasoning, attitudinal balance, and identity-protective cognition. Throughout the course, I challenged students with my proposition that "empathy is the most intellectually rigorous position." Rather than asking students to accept this proposition uncritically, I encouraged them to apply what they learned about human cognition and behavior to understand how people come to hold beliefs that might initially appear irrational. Many students reflected that their engagement with these theories had led them to appreciate the intellectual rigor involved in understanding perspectives different from their own.

My teaching philosophy is also informed by my work with the Qualitative Research Core at the Children's Hospital of Philadelphia. I regularly design and deliver qualitative and mixed-methods research workshops for physicians, nurses, doctoral researchers, junior research staff, and policy analysts. These efforts include one-hour introductory primers, three-hour focused workshops, and multi-month engagements in which I support research teams through the development and execution of their projects. In my role as an embedded methodological consultant, I guide investigators through research question development, study design, ethical and regulatory considerations, data collection, analysis, and scholarly writing. Working with researchers on active studies also allows me to tailor instruction to the decisions they are actually facing, rather than teaching methodological concepts in isolation from their application. Teaching research methods to professionals with different levels of experience has reinforced my belief that students learn most effectively when they understand how the material connects to questions they want to answer.